
Alexander Scriabin

1872–1915, RUSSIA

Composer, pianist, and mystic Scriabin was born in Moscow; his father was an aristocratic soldier, his mother a concert pianist. He studied piano alongside Rachmaninoff under Nikolai Zverev and attended the Moscow Conservatory. His early piano compositions were influenced by the Romanticism of Chopin and Liszt. Marrying Vera Isakovich in 1897, he became a teacher at the Conservatory. His First Symphony, an ambitious work with a choral finale, appeared in 1900. From around 1903, the style of his works became increasingly innovative, evolving away from conventional tonality. In 1904, he moved to Switzerland where, separated from his wife, he started a second family with Tatiana Schloezer. He adopted the mystical ideas of theosophy and pursued equivalences between colors and sounds—his *Prometheus, the Poem of Fire* (1910), had color projection as part of the score. He planned a multimedia work, *Mysterium*, which, performed in the Himalayas, was supposed to end the world in bliss. After returning to Russia, he died of blood poisoning.
